so that they were apart by a ful 180o. This would prevent the freak possibility of water gushing out and damaging the rocket. To our surprise, within minutes of Madhavan Nair getting the ports reversed, powerful water jets gushed out of the ports. The Vehicle Safety Officer had ensured the functioning of the fire-fighting system without realising that it could have wrecked the entire rocket. This was a lesson in foresight. Or did we have divine protection?

On 17 July 1980, 30 hours before the launch of the second SLV-3, the newspapers were fil ed with al kinds of predictions. One of the newspapers reported, “The Project Director is missing and could not be contacted.” Many reports preferred to trace the history of the first SLV3 flight, and recal ed how the third stage had failed to ignite because of lack of fuel and the rocket had nosedived into the ocean. Some highlighted SLV-3’s possible military implications in terms of acquiring the capability for building IRBMs. Some were a general prognosis of al that ailed our country and related it to the SLV-3. I knew that the next day’s launch was going to decide the future of the Indian space programme. In fact, to put it simply, the eyes of the whole nation were on us.